

Second Terminal Examination - 2079

Class: XI

Subject: C. English (0031)

Full Marks: 75

Time: 3 hrs.

SET B

Pass Marks: 30

Candidates are required to give their answers in their own words as far as practicable. The figures in the margin indicate full marks.

1. Read the following text and do the following tasks per instructions.

Many works of science fiction and some forecasts by serious technologists and futurologists predict that enormous amounts of computing power will be available. Let us suppose for a moment that these predictions are correct. One thing that later generations might do with their super-powerful computers is run detailed simulations of their forebears or people like their forebears. Because their computers would be so powerful, they could run many such simulations. Suppose that these simulated people are conscious (as they would be if the simulations were sufficiently fine-grained and if a certain quite widely accepted position in the philosophy of mind is correct). Then it could be the case that the vast majority of minds like ours do not belong to the original race but rather to people simulated by the advanced descendants of an original race. It is then possible to argue that, if this were the case, we would be rational to think that we are likely among the simulated minds rather than among the original biological ones. Therefore, if we do not think that we are currently living in a computer simulation, we are not entitled to believe that we will have descendants who will run many such simulations of their forebears.

If you have ever dabbled in role-playing games – either online or in old-fashioned meatspace – you'll know how easy it is to get attached to your avatar. It really hurts when your character gets mashed by a troll, felled by a dragon or slain by a warlock. The American sociologist (and enthusiastic gamer) William Sims Bainbridge has taken this relationship a step further, creating virtual representations for at least 17 deceased family members. In a 2013 essay about online avatars, he foresees a time when we'll be able to offload parts of our identity onto artificially intelligent simulations of ourselves that could function independently of us, and even persist after we die.

What sorts of responsibilities would we owe to these simulated humans? However, else we might feel about violent computer games, no one seriously thinks it's homicide when you blast a virtual assailant to oblivion. Yet it's no longer absurd to imagine that simulated people might one day exist and be possessed of some measure of autonomy and consciousness. Many philosophers believe that minds like ours don't have to be hosted by webs of neurons in our brains but could exist in many different sorts of material systems. If they're right, there's no obvious reason why sufficiently powerful computers couldn't hold consciousness in their circuits.

Hanson envisages that duplication of persons will be not only possible, but desirable. In the coming age of ems, people with particularly valuable mental traits would be ‘uploaded’ multiple times. And in general, people will want to make multiple copies of themselves anyway as a form of insurance. ‘They would prefer enough redundancy in their implementation to ensure that they can persist past unexpected disasters,’ Hanson says.

This scenario allows the possibility of duplicated selves, as once a mind has been transferred to a computer, making copies of it should be rather easy. Hanson says that the problem of identity then becomes fuzzy-edged: duplicates are ‘the same person’ initially, but gradually diverge in their personal identity as they proceed to live out separate lives, rather as identical twins do.

Adrian Kent, a theoretical physicist at the University of Cambridge, has started to explore this lacuna in moral reasoning. Suppose we become capable of emulating a human consciousness on a computer very cheaply, he suggested in a recent paper. We’d want to give this virtual being a rich and rewarding environment to interact with – a life worth living. Perhaps we might even do this for real people by scanning their brain in intricate detail and reproducing it computationally. You could imagine such a technology being used to ‘save’ people from terminal illness; some transhumanists today see it as a route to immortal consciousness.

Today, moral philosophers ponder the ethics of shaping human populations, with questions such as: what is the worth of a human life? What kind of lives should we strive to build? How much weight should we attach to the value of human diversity? But when it comes to thinking through the ethics of how to treat simulated entities, it’s not clear that we should rely on the intuitions we’ve developed in our flesh-and-blood world. We feel in our bones that there’s something wrong with killing a dog, and perhaps even a fly. But does it feel quite the same to shut down a simulation of a fly’s brain – or a human’s? When ‘life’ takes on new digital forms, our own experience might not serve as a reliable moral guide.

A. Mark (rewriting) the statements: *True, False, or Not Given.* (5×1 = 5)

- a. Super powerful computers will help to bring the virtual existence of our ancestors in very life like way.
- b. Simulated characters will be self-conscious if the simulation technology will be advanced and some philosophy regarding our mind will evolve in the coming age.
- c. Minds of our generation belongs to the simulated generation of our advanced descendants.
- d. Artificially simulated avatars do not produce strong sense of affiliation with our biological ones.
- e. Duplicate Intelligence and consciousness can alter and develop against each other since they will have separate bodies.

B. Fill in the gaps with appropriate words/phrases from the text. (5×1 = 5)

- a. We can develop a favorable and prosperous environment for any real human by scanning their brain in intricate and.....

- b. E-sports players feel dejected when their avatars..... a troll, felled by a dragon, or slain by a warlock.
- c. Its..... to attack and physically damage the digital characters and our enemies in video games.
- d. Simulated people might one day possess.....
- e. If we believe that we are currently living in a computer simulation, we also have to accept that our descendants will run lots of such

C. Answer the following questions. (5×1 = 5)

- a. Write the complete form of the abbreviated word "ems."
- b. According to the above text, what is the meaning of the word "meatspace"?
- c. What does William Sims Bainbridge hypothesize about future simulation?
- d. Why does the above text argue that it is a crime to blast digital characters?
- e. Why does Hanson envisage that in the future, 'duplication of people' will be possible and desirable?

2. Write short answers to the following questions. (5×2 = 10)

- a. Describe the portrait that the narrator saw in the room. (*The Oval Portrait*)
- b. Why did Aksionov think of killing himself? (*God Sees the Truth but Waits*)
- c. Simile and metaphor are the two major poetic devices used in this poem. Explain, citing examples from the poem, *All the World's a Stage*.
- d. If you believe that oral tradition is important, how would you maintain it? (Reference beyond the text: *Sharing Tradition*)
- e. Why does Mrs. Hale think that Mrs. Wright's worries about her preserves indicate her innocence? (*Trifles*)

3. Write long answers to the following questions. (2×5 = 10)

- a. What does the story tell us about the existence of an unfair system of justice? (*God Sees the Truth but Waits*)
- b. One of Steve Jobs' mottos was: 'Think differently.' Can this make a person succeed in life? What challenges are there in thinking differently? (*How to Live Before You Die*)

4. Write a letter to a friend discussing the issue of unmanaged street vendors in Kathmandu. (150 words) (7)

5. Can a person make a difference in society? Discuss citing examples from society who have brought significant changes. (180 words) (8)

6. Write an essay on "The Importance of Being Spiritual in the Wake of Modernity." Discuss the topic, importance, and role in nurturing morals in human beings. (300 words) (10)

7. Do as indicated in brackets and rewrite the sentences.

(10×1 = 10)

- a. She wore a diagonally striped dress. (*Identify the word class of the underlined word*)
- b. Our house is *practically* on the highway. The adverb “practically” modifies:
i. sentence ii. Prepositional phrase iii. Verb
- c. People (of /under) severe stress can experience breathing difficulties. (*Complete the sentence with the correct preposition*)
- d. Nita..... (be) my best friend since we were nine. (*Complete the sentence with the correct verb form*)
- e. If I had not put the helmet on, I (*could/should/would*) have been seriously injured. (*Choose the best option.*)
- f. The poor (is/are) suffering. (*Choose the correct verb*)
- g. Don't worry, mum. I promise I ... (will take/am going to take) good care of the plants. (*Choose the best option*)
- h. He was poor. He lived a lavish life. (*Join the sentences with 'Despite'*)
- i. Pal was driving a lorry in the hot weather of Death Valley. His forehead was covered with sweat. (*Join the sentences with a relative pronoun*)
- j. She looked upset since I forgot to wish her a birthday. (*Write whether the underlined verb is transitive, intransitive, or linking*)

8. Do as instructed.

(5×1 = 5)

- a. Arrange the following words in the correct alphabetical order:
caballeros, cabalettas, cabbalisms, cabalistic, cabaretting, cabbalists
- b. Which consonant sound remains unpronounced in the word ‘**cupboard**’? Mark it with an underline.
- c. When grandmother saw her grandson collecting coins like her son used to, she knew he was a **Chip off the old block**. The meaning of the underlined idiom in the sentence is:

i. To be so involved in trivial matters that you don’t get the essential facts

ii. A person is similar in behavior or actions to his parents.
- d. Form two new words with the prefix ‘**en-**’.
- e. Use the word “**beseech**” in a sensible sentence.

❧ - The End - ❧